to do things we haven't done before," says Batra. "Some may see it as a threat to jobs, but for me it makes life easier."

The future, it seems, is here. Shekhar Kapur's AI-generated *Warlord* is already in the development stage, while Sunny Leone's AI-powered avatar will headline *Kaur vs Kore*, touted as "India's first full AI superhero film" and "full-length AI feature film". That claim could come undone if *Chiranjeevi Hanuman—The Eternal*, expected to release in April 2026 in time for Hanuman Jayanti, beats it to theatres.

AI, says Dipankar Mukherjee—founder of Studio Blo, which is working with Kapur on *Warlord* and developing three other AI-driven IPs—has democratised filmmaking by bringing big scale within affordable reach. "2025 is year zero for AI," he says. "Everyone's evaluating it—cautious yet curious."

Approach with Caution

If there's trepidation in the industry around AI's disruptive potential, it stems from one unfortunate episode. On August 1, Aanand L. Rai's tragic romance *Raanjhanaa* was re-released in cinemas—only it wasn't entirely the same film Rai had made way back in 2013. Producers Eros changed the film's ending to a happy one, something Rai would discover through social media. "I totally believe AI is the future, but it should not be used to change the past," Rai told INDIA TODAY. The move sent ripples through the industry, with many expressing concern about the gross misuse of the technology and the need to introduce legal guidelines to protect the rights of artists. "Legally, we know it belongs to the studio, but that doesn't mean we aren't taking any action against them," Rai said. "We are finding different routes so that we can safeguard ourselves in the future from this ruthlessness."

Personality rights is another area AI is causing concern. Several actors such as Amitabh Bachchan and Anil Kapoor, and artists like Arijit Singh, have moved courts to stop the unauthorised use of their name, voice, mannerisms or any other personal attribute, by AI. Aishwarya Rai and Abhishek Bachchan recently filed a lawsuit against YouTube and Google over

FIGHTING DIGITAL CLONES





Few professionals are as jittery about artificial intelligence as actors. As deepfakes and digital replicas proliferate, law firms such as Naik Naik & Co. and intellectual property (IP) specialists like lawyer Priyanka Khimani have become hotlines for celebrities seeking to guard their likeness, voice, iconic dialogues and persona from misuse. ***Amitabh Bachchan*** was among the first to draw a line—moving the Delhi High Court and successfully restraining a jeweller from exploiting his "celebrity status". Soon after, ***Anil Kapoor*** secured a similar order protecting his personality rights from unauthorised commercial use.

The anxiety runs deeper. Voice and dubbing artists, too, are lawyering up—worried that AI could clone their work and recreate new performances without credit or pay. The Association of Voice Artists (AVA) has enlisted lawyer Akshay Shetty to educate its 1,000-odd members on royalty clauses. "If a voice is used to train an AI model, it can get replicated to create a new product. Ideally, the artist should be paid for the derivative work as well," says Shetty. The AVA has even drafted a standard contract aimed squarely at such AI-enabled projects—signalling the times to come.



"I totally believe AI is the future, but then it should only be used for the future and not to change the past"

AANAND L. RAI
Director, Raanjhana

